AI in the Real World

Data, Power, & Society - Day 03

The US Census and Data

CMSE 492 (aka CMSE 101) • Fall 2026

Prof. Danny Caballero

This Week's Agenda

1. **Course intro** (✓)
2. **Group the class!** - Get up and move around! (✓)
3. **Wednesday: Constructing Categories** - How we perceive people matters (✓).
4. **Wednesday: Who do we make into groups?** – We'll work through the Census timeline together (✓)
    - *In your assigned groups*
5. **Friday: First Case - Census Data** – Focusing on the Data in DTPA (you're here ✓)

Exit ticket – Your third one is due by 5pm today on D2L.
Case Analyses - Today, we will work to complete the first case study; due Sunday at 11:59pm

We have been trying to switch to a classroom with A/C

- Devin and I have been in contact with Registrar's Office; no response yet
- Look for an email from me if we make a change; sign will appear on C102

Wednesday's Activity: Tracing racial/ethnic grouping over time

Create a historical timeline of changes to the US Census

Google Slides

1. In your preparatory materials, we included the Pew research center's interactive tool on racial data collected on the US census: https://www.pewresearch.org/interactives/what-census-calls-us/
2. In this activity you will select a racial category to follow over time
    - Discuss in your group at least 2 categories to dive into as a group
    - Using events that were happening in the US (see the slides 3 and 4 for examples, and slide 5 for more links), place your census categories on this timeline
    - On your group's slide, create a representation of this history

Did your group complete the timeline before today's class?

Today's Activity: Completing your first Case Study - Data

Use your timeline as an artifact in your Case Study

To help you meet the standard this week, we provide these scaffolding questions:

> *also appearing in the Google Doc instructions*

- **Collection:** What was collected, by what method, and by whom? Was race self-reported or assigned by an enumerator? How did that change over time and why?
- **Criteria:** Who is included and who is excluded by the categories themselves? Name a specific group and a specific census year. Unpack or follow what happened.
- **Manipulation / Encoding:** What happens to a response after it is submitted? Look for editing, imputation, recoding, and back-end processing rules. *You might need to do more research here.*
- **Bias & Inequity:** Give a concrete downstream consequence. Who lost funding, representation, visibility, or safety because of how the data was structured? *You might need to do more research here.*

Take notes in your Group's tab of the Google Doc

What does a complete First Case Study look like?

Your group will need to:

- Complete the introduction and information on the case section **in a narrative format** with proper spelling and grammar
- Include your **timeline as an artifact** and draw from it
  - Be specific about the group(s) you followed and the history you've researched
- Write **in a narrative format** answers to the questions under **Data** portion of the DTPA Framework Analysis section
  - Take into account the scaffolding questions not just the generic questions to achieve the standard
- Write **in a narrative format** answers to the questions under **Data Literacy** portion of the Four Pillars of AI Literacy section
- Provide **in APA format** primary and secondary resources that you used
- Reflect **in a narrative format** as a group noting your impressions, disagreements, or points of contention as you worked through this case

Reminders for this weekend

Exit Tickets, D2L, and the Course Website

- Don't forget to complete today's Exit Ticket by 5pm (on D2L)
- Case study due 11:59pm Sunday
- Individual and Metacognitive Reflection due 11:59pm Sunday
- Spend time before Sunday (~90 minutes) going over next week's preparatory materials
  - Forum Post due 11:59pm **Tuesday** <- *No class on Monday!*

Have a great Labor Day weekend



MSU vs Toledo (20:00 tonight on FS1)

